Service Manual for the Lord’s Army

Because believers are chosen of God, holy and beloved, they are to put on Christlike character held together by love — and to let the peace of Christ arbitrate, the word of Christ dwell richly, and the name of Christ authorize all they do.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer's Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord's Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

Why we wear the uniform

Colossians 3:12a · Outline I.A — Identity before instruction

Whose we are	What we are	Why we are
ἐκλεκτός “Chosen of God” — Scripture speaks of election to encourage believers, not to make them anxious chosen	**ἅγιοι** “Holy” — saints in position, even the troubled Corinthians (1 Cor 1:2) same word as 1:2	**ἀγαπάω** “Beloved” — loved and remaining loved; His love argues for ours Perf. Pass.

We do not dress this way to become chosen, holy and beloved. We dress this way because we already are.

What we are to wear

Colossians 3:12b · Outline I.B — “Put on” (ἐνδύω)

1 A heart of compassion

σπλάγχνα οἰκτιρμοῦ
Sensitivity to those who suffer — “your hurt in my heart”

2 Kindness

χρηστότης
A sweet disposition seen in thoughtful dealings with others

3 Humility

ταπεινοφροσύνη
A realistic view of oneself — unlike the false humility of 2:18, 23

4 Gentleness

πραΰτης
Not weakness — strength under control

5 Patience

μακροθυμία
Long-suffering that does not retaliate (1:11)

= Three groups

Treatment of others (1–2) · estimate of ourselves (3–4) · response to provocation (5)

How to wear it — and keep it on

Colossians 3:13–14 · Outline I.C–D

1	**Bearing with one another — v.13a** Putting up with others and enduring discomfort — especially when it is not comfortable	**ἀνέχω** to hold oneself up
2	**Forgiving each other — v.13b** To forgive is to give grace: no grudges, no nursing a grievance	**χαρίζομαι** built on charis
3	**“Just as the Lord forgave you” — v.13c** Freely, fully, while we were undeserving — the standard leaves no room for conditions	**Eph 4:32**
4	**Put on love — v.14** The outer garment or belt over everything else — “the perfect bond of unity”	**σύνδεσμος** a ligament, a binding

The code of conduct

Colossians 3:15–17 · Outline II.A–C

v.15	The peace of Christ is for arbitration — let it make the call, within God's revealed will; and be thankful	**βραβεύω** to act as umpire (cf. 2:18)
v.16a	The word of Christ is for application — let it dwell in you richly, at home	**ἐνοικέω** "the word of Christ" — only here
v.16b	Teaching and admonishing one another — the work of every believer, with grace	**—** cf. 1:28
v.16c	Psalms, hymns and spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts	**ψαλμός · ὕμνος · ᾠδή** cf. Eph 5:18–21
v.17	The name of Christ is for authorization — whatever you do, in word or deed, as His representative, giving thanks	**—** principles, not rule lists

Word-filled (Col 3:16) and Spirit-filled (Eph 5:18) produce the same results: song, thanks and submission.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 3:12–17 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does Paul remind believers that they are “chosen of God, holy and beloved” before giving commands?

2. How should the “peace of Christ” function in decision-making, according to the study?

Apply

Get Dressed on Purpose
Each morning this week, pray through the five virtues of verse 12 by name as you get dressed.

Forgive as You Were Forgiven
Choose to forgive that person before God in prayer, and if appropriate take one step toward reconciliation.

In one line: The Lord’s army wears Christ’s character, held together by love — ruled by His peace, filled with His Word, acting in His name.